

A JPP RESOURCE COLLECTION GUIDE

BEFORE YOU PUBLISH

An Independent Author Readiness & Planning Guide

For writers preparing to move from manuscript to publication

Write it. Prepare it. Protect it. Publish with purpose.



Before the Book Becomes a Book

A note from Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing

Finishing a manuscript is an accomplishment worth celebrating. But a finished manuscript and a publication-ready book are not the same thing.

Publishing introduces a new set of decisions. Editing. Design. ISBNs. Copyright. Pricing. Distribution. Proofs. Metadata. Marketing. Inventory. Each decision becomes part of the book readers will eventually hold in their hands.

Before You Publish was created to help independent authors slow the process down long enough to ask the right questions.

This guide will not tell you which publishing path to choose, nor will it provide a one-size-fits-all formula for publishing a book. Instead, it will help you identify what you already know, what still needs attention, and what you may need to research before moving forward.

You do not have to know everything today. You do need to know what you don't know.

What This Guide Will Help You Examine

YOUR READER

Who are you writing for, and what do you want the book to accomplish?

YOUR MANUSCRIPT

Is it finished, or is it truly ready for production?

YOUR PUBLISHING PATH

Which responsibilities will belong to you?

YOUR BOOK'S IDENTITY

Do you understand the identifiers, rights, formats, and information attached to your book?

YOUR PRODUCTION PLAN

How will the manuscript become a finished physical or digital product?

YOUR NUMBERS

Do you understand what it costs to produce, distribute, and sell the book?

YOUR READERSHIP PLAN

How will people discover the book after it becomes available?

The goal is not to rush toward “published.”
The goal is to arrive prepared.

Who Is This Book For?

Before you choose a cover, price, platform, or publication date, know who you are trying to reach.

A book written for “everyone” can become difficult to position for anyone. Identifying your primary reader helps guide decisions about tone, design, format, pricing, description, marketing, and even where the book should be available.

1 Who is the primary reader for this book?

2 What need, interest, question, experience, or desire brings that reader to this book?

3 What do I want the reader to feel, understand, learn, question, or do after finishing it?

4 What genre or category best describes the book?

5 What other books might my intended reader already be reading?

My Book in One Sentence

My book is a _____ for _____

that _____.

READER FIRST

Publishing decisions become easier when you stop asking, “What do I like?” and begin asking, “What serves this book and its intended reader?”

Finished Is Not the Same as Ready

Typing “The End” finishes the draft. Preparing it for a reader requires another kind of work.

After spending months, or years, with a manuscript, it becomes difficult to see it objectively. Familiarity can hide repetition, inconsistencies, missing information, formatting problems, and even simple errors.

Before moving into book production, stop and evaluate the manuscript itself.

Manuscript Readiness Check

- ☐ I have completed the full manuscript.
- ☐ I have stepped away from the manuscript and returned to it with fresh eyes.
- ☐ I have completed at least one substantive revision.
- ☐ Names, dates, locations, timelines, and recurring details have been checked for consistency.
- ☐ Chapters and sections appear in their intended order.
- ☐ Someone other than me has read the manuscript.
- ☐ Appropriate editing and/or proofreading has been completed or planned.
- ☐ Quotations, photographs, illustrations, lyrics, or other third-party material have been reviewed for necessary permissions.
- ☐ Front matter has been considered.
- ☐ Back matter has been considered.
- ☐ I know which version of the manuscript is the current master file.
- ☐ My master manuscript and important production files are backed up.

My Manuscript Still Needs:

JPP CHECKPOINT

Do not let excitement about publishing convince you to stop revising too soon. Correcting a manuscript is easier before it becomes a formatted book.

How Will This Book Reach the Reader?

There is more than one route to publication. Each comes with different responsibilities, timelines, costs, and levels of control.

Traditional Publishing

A publisher generally acquires publishing rights and manages much of the production and distribution process. Authors typically submit through the publisher's required process and may need representation depending on the publisher.

Independent / Self-Publishing

The author assumes the role traditionally handled by a publisher, or hires professionals to perform those functions. This can provide significant control, but it also places responsibility for production and business decisions on the author.

Assisted or Hybrid Services

Some companies provide publishing services for a fee or through other financial arrangements. Services and contracts vary considerably.

Before signing anything, understand exactly **what you are purchasing, what rights you retain, what the provider controls, and what happens after publication.**

Before You Pay a Provider

What exactly will they deliver?

Who owns the completed files?

Which rights am I granting?

What happens when our working relationship ends?

Who Will Handle It?

For each responsibility, mark who will take it on.

PUBLISHING RESPONSIBILITY	ME	PROFESSIONAL / PROVIDER	STILL DECIDING
Editing	☐	☐	☐
Cover design	☐	☐	☐
Interior formatting	☐	☐	☐
Illustrations	☐	☐	☐
ISBN/identifiers	☐	☐	☐
Metadata	☐	☐	☐
Print/eBook files	☐	☐	☐
Distribution	☐	☐	☐
Pricing	☐	☐	☐
Marketing	☐	☐	☐
Inventory	☐	☐	☐
Recordkeeping	☐	☐	☐

Notes on Providers or Professionals I'm Considering

CONTROL AND RESPONSIBILITY TRAVEL TOGETHER

The more of the publishing process you control, the more of the publishing process you must understand.

Learn the Language Before You Need It

A book carries more information than its title and author's name.

You do not need to become an expert in every publishing term. You should, however, understand the information associated with your book and know which requirements apply to your publishing plan.

ISBN

An International Standard Book Number identifies a particular book product and edition. Different formats or editions may require separate ISBNs.

I need to research: _____

Copyright

Copyright protects original creative expression under applicable law. Copyright ownership and copyright registration are related concepts, but they are not identical.

I need to research: _____

LCCN

A Library of Congress Control Number is associated with a Library of Congress catalog record. It is not an ISBN and does not replace copyright registration.

Does this apply to my publication? _____

Imprint

An imprint is the publishing name appearing on a book and in publishing records.

My intended imprint/publisher name: _____

Metadata

The information used to describe and identify a book, such as title, contributor information, description, categories, keywords, publication information, and other product details.

Format & Edition

Paperback, hardcover, eBook, audiobook, revised edition, large print, and other versions can represent distinct publishing products.

Research List

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ ISBN requirements | ☐ Formats and editions |
| ☐ Copyright | ☐ Metadata requirements |
| ☐ LCCN eligibility/process | ☐ Rights and permissions |
| ☐ Publishing/imprint information | |

KNOW THE DIFFERENCE

ISBN, copyright, and LCCN serve different purposes. One does not automatically replace another.

Build the Book

A manuscript is the content. Production turns that content into the product the reader receives.

A typical production process may include:

EDIT » FORMAT » DESIGN » REVIEW » PROOF » CORRECT » FINALIZE

Interior

- ☐ Trim size
- ☐ Margins and gutters
- ☐ Typography
- ☐ Chapter openings
- ☐ Headers/footers
- ☐ Page numbers
- ☐ Images/illustrations
- ☐ Front matter
- ☐ Back matter

Cover

- ☐ Correct dimensions for the chosen format
- ☐ Front cover
- ☐ Spine, when applicable
- ☐ Back cover
- ☐ Title and author name
- ☐ Book description
- ☐ Barcode/ISBN placement, when applicable
- ☐ Image quality
- ☐ Legibility at thumbnail size

Production Notes

A file can look correct on a computer screen and still reveal problems when produced as an actual book.

- ☐ Cover alignment
 - ☐ Spine placement
 - ☐ Margins
 - ☐ Page sequence
 - ☐ Blank pages
 - ☐ Image quality
 - ☐ Illustrations and captions
 - ☐ Headers and page numbers
 - ☐ Typos and formatting shifts
 - ☐ Front and back matter
 - ☐ Final pricing/ISBN information where applicable

Do not review what you intended to create. Review what is actually on the page.

Corrections I Discovered During Proofing

A Sale Is Not the Same as Profit

Your retail price is only one number in the financial life of a book.

Before setting a price, understand the costs and deductions that may apply to your particular publishing and sales model.

My Book Numbers

Estimated printing/manufacturing cost	\$
Planned retail price	\$
Platform/distribution deductions	\$
Wholesale considerations	\$
Shipping/packaging for direct orders	\$
Other per-book expenses	\$
Estimated amount remaining per sale	\$

Costs Before the First Sale

Editing	\$
Cover design	\$
Formatting	\$
Illustration	\$
ISBN/administrative expenses	\$
Proofs	\$
Website/marketing materials	\$
Other	\$

TOTAL ESTIMATED PRE-PUBLICATION INVESTMENT

\$

PRICE WITH INFORMATION, NOT EMOTION

A price should reflect your publishing model, production costs, market considerations, and business goals, not simply what “sounds right.”

Questions to Answer

Work through these before you order inventory or set a launch date.

How many books would I need to sell to recover my initial investment?

Will I sell books directly? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Unsure

If I hold inventory, where will it be stored?

How will I track expenses and income?

Available Does Not Mean Discovered

A book can be available for purchase and still remain invisible to the people who would value it.

DISTRIBUTION ANSWERS

Where can someone obtain the book?

MARKETING ANSWERS

How will that person learn the book exists, and why might they care?

My Discovery Plan

My first likely readers are:

Three communities that naturally connect with this book:

1.

2.

3.

Where Does My Intended Reader Already Spend Time?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Libraries | ☐ Community groups |
| ☐ Book clubs | ☐ Social media |
| ☐ Schools | ☐ Conferences/events |
| ☐ Churches/faith communities | ☐ Veteran/military organizations |
| ☐ Professional organizations | ☐ Other: <hr/> |

Before Launch

Gather what readers, retailers, libraries, and event hosts will ask for.

-
- ☐ A clear book description
 - ☐ Author biography
 - ☐ Author photograph, if appropriate
 - ☐ Book cover images
 - ☐ Purchase information
 - ☐ Website or landing page
 - ☐ Social-media assets
 - ☐ Launch announcement
 - ☐ Outreach/contact list
 - ☐ Event materials, if applicable
 - ☐ A plan beyond release day

The Question That Matters

What will I do during the 30 days **after** publication?

Publication is an event.
Readership is built over time.

Where Do You Stand Today?

This is not a test. There is no score.

For each area, mark the column that most accurately reflects where you are right now.

AREA	READY	NEEDS ATTENTION	NEED TO RESEARCH
Intended reader	☐	☐	☐
Manuscript	☐	☐	☐
Editing	☐	☐	☐
Permissions/rights	☐	☐	☐
Publishing path	☐	☐	☐
ISBN	☐	☐	☐
Copyright	☐	☐	☐
LCCN, if applicable	☐	☐	☐
Cover	☐	☐	☐
Interior formatting	☐	☐	☐
Metadata	☐	☐	☐
Pricing	☐	☐	☐
Distribution	☐	☐	☐
Proofing	☐	☐	☐
Marketing	☐	☐	☐
Launch plan	☐	☐	☐
Direct sales/inventory	☐	☐	☐
Recordkeeping	☐	☐	☐

My Three Priorities

Before moving forward, the three areas requiring my attention are:

1.

2.

3.

WHAT I NEED TO LEARN

WHO OR WHAT CAN HELP ME?

A gap you can see is a gap you can address.

Look at the Book, Not the Dream

Excitement is part of publishing. So is restraint.

Before approving files, ordering inventory, announcing a release, or making the book available to readers, stop one more time.

Ask Yourself

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Have I reviewed the final manuscript? | ☐ Have I checked every illustration, photograph, caption, and credit? |
| ☐ Have I reviewed the final cover? | ☐ Have I verified page order and front/back matter? |
| ☐ Have I checked the title and author/contributor names everywhere they appear? | ☐ Do I understand the retail price and my expected compensation? |
| ☐ Are the correct identifiers attached to the correct formats? | ☐ Do I know where the book will be available? |
| ☐ Have I reviewed the final metadata? | ☐ Do I have a plan for direct orders, if offering them? |
| ☐ Have I checked the book description? | ☐ Do I have final production files safely stored? |
| ☐ Have I reviewed a proof or appropriate final-format preview? | ☐ Do I know what happens after publication? |

My Book Is Ready When...

One Thing I Refuse to Rush:

Your reader will never see the months of decisions behind the book.

They will only experience the result.

Publish With Purpose

A manuscript begins with an idea.

A book requires decisions.

Independent publishing asks an author to move between creativity and business, instinct and information, excitement and patience.

You do not need to have every answer when you begin.

You should be willing to ask the questions, research what you do not understand, seek qualified help when you need it, and protect the work by refusing to rush decisions simply because publication feels close.

Write with intention.

Prepare with care.

Protect what you've created.

Publish with purpose.

Keep Learning

Find more complimentary guides, activities, and educational materials in the JPP Resource Center.

[[Resource Center link](#)]

Part of the Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing Resource Collection.



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